

Pasta Around the World

Pasta was brought to Italy from the Middle East in the 13th century and became the simple staple that still reigns supreme there today. Luckily, the rest of the world caught on in the 20th century, and you can now eat delicious pasta – simply dressed or enveloped in rich sauces – all around the world.

ITALY

Antica Focacceria San Francesco
inexpensive

Via Paternostro 58, Palermo, Sicily; www.afsf.it

Five generations of the Conticello family have cooked in this lovely old building, which has a spacious courtyard restaurant. It's renowned for typical Sicilian dishes such as *pasta con le sarde*: spaghetti with sardines, wild fennel, pine nuts, and currants. At lunch times it operates almost as a fast-food place, with dishes served on plastic plates to eat or carry out.

Trattoria Meloncello inexpensive

Via Saragozza 240, Bologna; +39 51 613 947

The decor is down-to-earth 1950s Italian, but the food is timeless; this is simple food at its best. The affable owner always explains the day's menu, rather than offering a printed version, which usually includes a very good homemade tortellini as well as tagliatelle with a rich *ragù*. The house wine is very good too.

Da Nello moderate

Via Monte Grappa 2, Bologna; www.ristorantedanello.it

This venerable institution is always packed. Diners are ushered downstairs amidst mouthwatering fragrances and uniformed waiters hurrying with steaming plates of *tortellini in brodo*, *pappardelle alla caccia* (game sauce), and *cotoletta alla bolognese* (escalope with *parmigiano* and Parma ham).

Ristorante Pappone moderate

Marina del Cantone 23, Massa Lubrense, Naples; www.hotelcertosa.com

The restaurant inside the Hotel la Certosa on the Amalfi Coast serves large platters of huge, pale *maccheroni* tubes cooked perfectly *al dente* and accompanied by the day's fish catch stewed in delicate tomato. The restaurant sits on a beachfront terrace overlooking a secluded cove.

PARIS, FRANCE

Italian cuisine in the French capital steps many rungs up the gastronomic ladder, from the basic trattoria to stylish restaurants in which both Italian and French chefs bring a creative intelligence to even the more traditional dishes.

L'Enoteca moderate

25 rue Charles V; www.enoteca.fr

Wine takes center stage in this cozy 17th-century locale in the Marais; the restaurant has won awards for its selection. Creative mouthwatering pasta options are *linguine ai frutti di mare* refreshed with citrus zest, and squid-ink black cannelloni filled with sea bass and ricotta.

La Locanda moderate

8 rue de Dragon; www.lalocanda.fr

This sun-filled restaurant in St-Germain-des-Près is located in an 18th-century town house and offers a wonderful "Trio of Pasta": three of the day's specials as a surprise. Fresh hand-fished seafood arrives daily and also ranks high as a favorite – try the spaghetti with lobster or *vongole* (clams) from Brittany.

LONDON, UK

The "Italian Eating Place" was the first Italian restaurant set up in London. Joseph Moretti opened it in 1803 to cater mostly to Italians, but the cuisine later became fashionable thanks to the trend for traveling Europe on "Grand Tours." These days there are hundreds of Italian restaurants in London, which import genuine ingredients from Italy.

Carluccio's inexpensive

Garrick St., Covent Garden, WC2; www.carluccios.com

Brainchild of jovial TV chef Antonio Carluccio, his elegant flagship serves pasta dishes from all over Italy. The *penne giardiniera* is a tasty mix of zucchini, fried spinach balls, chili pepper, and garlic.

Locanda Locatelli expensive

8 Seymour St., W1; www.locandalocatelli.com

This Michelin-starred restaurant is reputed to serve the best Italian food in the city. The divine house pasta comes stuffed with pheasant and rosemary, or smothered with gently stewed octopus.

